



India could be Netflix's saving grace

Read more about issues plaguing Netflix and how an India-specific focus could be a saving grace for the service. <https://digit.in/feb20-27>



Piratebay streaming service

Torrent site, Piratebay, now lets users to stream OTT content with their new streaming feature Baystream. <https://digit.in/feb20-28>



The booming streaming services industry might be making it difficult for the Indian consumer to find the right entertainment

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ou reach home, tired and exhausted after a long day, and fire up your TV to continue your favourite series,

but somehow, you can't seem to find it. Wait, weren't they saying it'll move to some different service this year? While you Google to check the same, you get an ad for an upcoming superhero show on this brand new streaming service. You click on it, only to discover that it hasn't launched in India yet. Irritated, you decide to just rewatch the highlights of last night's game. But hey, isn't that on a different streaming app which your TV doesn't support yet? It's official – things are getting a bit crazy in the streaming services scene right now. To understand how we got here, we have to rewatch this from season one.

THE PLOT SO FAR

Going into a detailed history of the rise of OTT and streaming services in India, and the main driving factors, deserve its own article. While there were some OTT platforms and

services before, the entry of major international names like Netflix & Amazon's Prime Video worked as a shot in the arm for the sector. Fast forward a couple of years to 2019, and you have about 30-odd streaming services available, independent as well as backed by existing media companies, each with its 'unique' offering vying for your attention. Established players like Netflix and Prime Video are investing in original local content, whereas newer entrants like Apple TV+ and Flipkart Videos are going all out to cut a slice of the user-base pie. A PWC report predicts that the industry in India will be worth nearly ₹12000 crores by 2023.

THE ENDLESS CATALOGUE PHENOMENON

Streaming services are a prime example of "the more the merrier" not holding true for everything. While a larger, exhaustive catalogue of content might seem great to begin with, it makes it even more difficult to choose something new to watch. Now, with a large number of streaming platforms

offering everything from movies, shows, catch-up TV, live sports and events, regional content and more, the choice is even harder.

Fortunately, some content providers are addressing this with technology. Netflix's content recommendation system is well-known, and even well-explained by themselves. It takes into account myriad factors to ensure that a highly optimised selection of content is first presented to you as you log in. They've even gone as far as showing different people different thumbnail art for the same show based on their behaviour. However, this could also end up being counterintuitive – if the algorithm has completed most of the choosing work for you, isn't it making you worse at making a choice? Think about it the next time you're stuck in an endless loop of 'More Like This' on Netflix.

However, not every content provider has a robust recommendation engine to fall back on. Additionally, due to the rampant password sharing behaviour, the recommendation algorithm ends up absorbing the